‘I am not saying you are inefficient,’ I continued. ‘But I have to say that you are not doing your job by keeping silent when others are trying to ride roughshod over me and destroy my dream of making a liquid engine, which would be much superior to the solid ones.’

‘I think you need rest,’ said a calm Dhawan. ‘Why don’t you retire for the night and let’s talk about this over breakfast tomorrow?’

Back in my room, I repeatedly washed my face and found that my eyes were red-shot. May be it was the sun, may be it was my anger. Through the restless night, I had hazy dreams of red-fuming nitric acid.

The next morning, I met Dhawan and Brahm Prakash in the guest house dining room for breakfast. Dhawan, as calm as ever, was seated at the head of the table, flanked by us. I was feeling slightly better than the previous night. Dhawan did not get back to my allegations of some people trying to scuttle the liquid engine concept and my accusation that he was being a silent spectator. But he appeared to have considered seriously whatever I had told him.

‘Failures are part of the game,’ Dhawan started. ‘You have been trying something that you strongly believe in, and I appreciate that. Now, why don’t you try for some collaboration with a country willing to help us develop this engine?’

There was not any country then, keen to join hands with us, I knew, but Dhawan’s words sounded encouraging. I also realised that even if I strike a deal with another country for the liquid propulsion system, it would not make me happy till some seniors continued to disregard the promise of the liquid engine. By now I was convinced that they either did not understand the future or chose to ignore it to further their own interests.

‘Collaborations I can look for,’ I said. ‘But only if I can report to you …’

I sensed an unease in Dhawan, and quickly added ‘… formally or informally.’

Dhawan patiently explained to me how as an organisation I couldn’t overstep my seniors and report to the chairman directly.